

COGNITIVE BEHAVIORAL THERAPY (CBT) – SESSION 4

Reviewing Worry Time, Problem-Solving & Strengthening New Beliefs

Fictional Educational Example — Full Detailed

SESSION INFORMATION

Client: RK (35 y/o Male)

Therapist: Dr. A.

Session #: 4 of 16

Focus: Worry Time review + Problem-solving + Cognitive v

PRE-SESSION THERAPIST NOTES

Client practiced Worry Time most days with moderate success. He found it helpful for reducing background worry during the day. He also attempted the new behavioral experiment. Today's plan: Review Worry Time and experiments, introduce structured problem-solving, continue working on the core belief about perfection/competence, and assign integrated homework.

SESSION START & HOMEWORK REVIEW

Therapist: Good morning, RK. How was your week? Let's start with how the Worry Time technique went.

Client: It was better than I expected. Writing worries down and telling myself "I'll deal with this at 8 PM" really reduced the constant background anxiety during the day. I still worried during Worry Time, but it felt more contained.

Therapist: That's excellent feedback. Many people find that just having a designated time reduces the power of worry during the rest of the day. How did the new behavioral experiment go — sharing an idea without over-preparing?

Client: I tried it in a small team meeting. I shared an idea without spending hours preparing every possible question. It went okay — no one criticized it. I felt anxious beforehand but much better afterward.

Therapist: That's great progress. What did you learn?

Client: That I don't always need to over-prepare to be competent. People still took my idea seriously.

INTRODUCING STRUCTURED PROBLEM-SOLVING

Therapist: Many people with anxiety also benefit from learning structured problem-solving skills. When we're anxious, our thinking can become very black-and-white or catastrophic, which makes solving problems harder. Would you like to learn a simple step-by-step method?

Client: Yes, that sounds useful. I often feel stuck when there's a work problem.

Therapist: Great. The steps are:

1. Define the problem clearly and specifically
2. Brainstorm as many solutions as possible (even silly ones)
3. Evaluate the pros and cons of each solution
4. Choose the best solution(s) and make a plan
5. Carry out the plan and review how it went

Therapist: Let's practice with one current work problem you're facing.

(They work through a current issue: difficulty saying no to extra tasks from seniors. They brainstorm solutions together and choose one to try.)

CONTINUING WORK ON CORE BELIEFS

Therapist: We've been working on the belief "I have to be perfect or they will see I'm not good enough." From the experiments and thought records, how much do you believe it now?

Client: Down to about 45%. The experiments are really helping.

Therapist: That's significant movement. Let's strengthen it further with a technique called a ****Continuum****. On a scale from 0 (completely incompetent) to 100 (completely competent), where would you place yourself overall as a software engineer?

Client: Maybe 65–70.

Therapist: And where would you place yourself on days when you make a small mistake or don't over-prepare?

Client: Probably around 40–50 on those days.

Therapist: Interesting. So your overall rating is 65–70, but it drops sharply on days with small mistakes. This shows that your mind is treating small mistakes as proof of overall incompetence, even though your general rating is quite good. Does that make sense?

Client: Yes... I see what you mean. One mistake doesn't erase all the other good work.

HOMEWORK ASSIGNMENT

Therapist: For this week:

1. Continue daily diary + Worry Time practice
2. Use the problem-solving steps on at least one work issue
3. Continue rating belief in the perfectionistic thought and using the balanced alternative
4. Try one more small behavioral experiment related to saying "no" or setting a boundary at work

SESSION SUMMARY & FEEDBACK

Therapist: Today we reviewed your successful experiments, introduced structured problem-solving, and used the Continuum technique to look at your overall competence. What felt most useful?

Client: The problem-solving steps were practical. And the Continuum helped me see that I'm rating myself too harshly on bad days.

Therapist: Excellent. Any questions?

Client: No, I'm clear.

POST-SESSION THERAPIST NOTES

- Client continuing to engage well with homework and experiments.
- Worry Time technique is helping contain daily worry.
- Introduced problem-solving skills and client responded positively.
- Continued progress on core belief (now at ~45% belief).
- Next session: Review problem-solving attempts, deepen work on core beliefs (possibly using historical review), continue behavioral experiments.

Disclaimer: This is a completely fictional but realistic simulation created solely for educational and AI training purposes. It does not represent any real person or therapy.